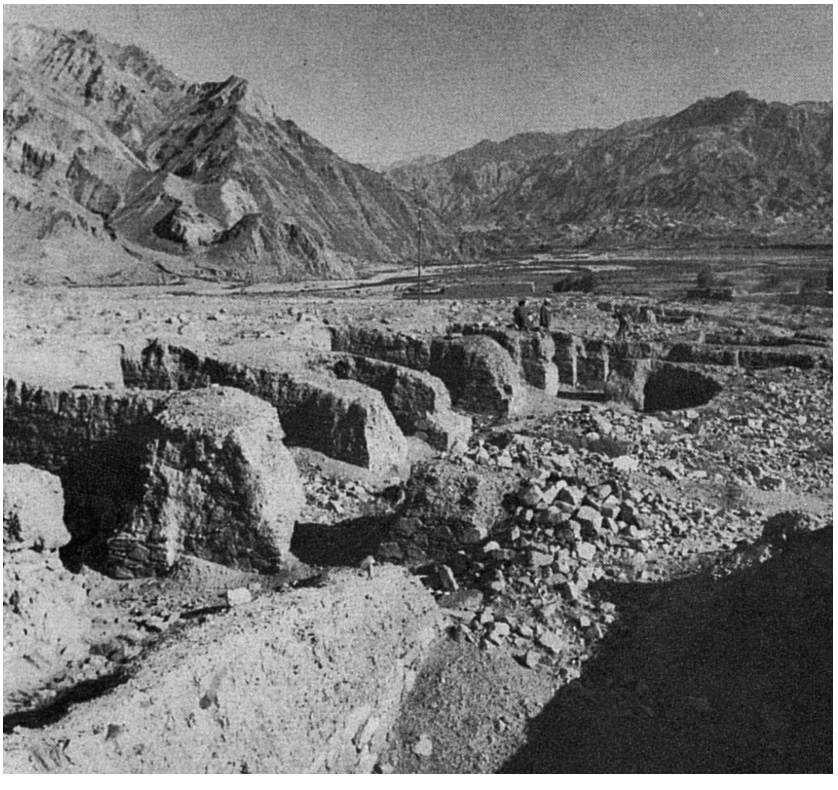


Figure 3.20 *Barfak II/"Danestama," east side of central courtyard. From Le Berre 1970: pl. IIa.*

with molded decorative designs in shallow relief appliqué.[73] In addition to Ghulghula's extensive ceramic finds, earlier documentation of the site had already revealed two notable mosques: one with a *qibla ivan* overlooking a large courtyard; and the other, a larger one probably with four *ivan*s around a courtyard.[74] Finally, the rediscovery of intricately carved, double-leaf wooden doors (Figure 3.13) strongly suggested Shansabani presence here: the arabesque motifs in relief, contained within incised geometric shapes, create an overall effect not unlike a door leaf recovered during Jam-Firuzkuh's surface explorations.[75] The pre-Islamic structural cores at Ghulghula, then, quite possibly received additional architectural details during Shansabani occupation in the second half of the twelfth century.

Franco-Afghan surveys and excavations on the western slopes of the Ghulghula promontory in 2014–2015 revealed extensive historical remains of palatial architecture, albeit deteriorated due to modern occupation and modification. Nevertheless, elevations and plans of the older architectural remnants – some extending up to 10 meters above ground – were identified and analyzed, resulting in close parallels to surviving Ghaznavid